

A Frame House as White as Snow.

The Uilla Indian Agency was founded in 1851, and its location in Echo Meadows was a reflection of events, which had began in prehistoric times. A footpath there, created by the ancient people who had sought the resources of the area, later became a major trail used by the great tribes of historic times. This trail was later followed by thousands of traveling immigrants with their wagons and herds of stock.

The founding of Marcus and Narcissa Whitman's mission at Waiilatpu¹³ in 1836 set in motion a series of

episodes that resulted in the Umatilla River crossing at Echo becoming the major Oregon Trail route. It was Marcus Whitman that led the first "Great Migration" west in 1843, and, once this Oregon-bound train of about 1,000 men, women, and children reached the Whitmans' mission, the emigrants made their way into the Oregon Territory from that location. Thousands of others followed this route, until November 1847, when the Whitmans and eleven others were killed at their mission. Prior to this tragedy, the Cayuse would barter oxen or horses for cattle along the Oregon Trail. Cayuse traders also brought the immigrants fish from the Columbia River, and fresh vegetables from their gardens. However, after the Whitmans' deaths, the fear caused by the brief "Cayuse War" that followed, and the discovery of gold in California in 1848 resulted in fewer takers for the Oregon Trail.

¹³West of present day Walla-Walla.

Oregon fever built up again during the 1850's, and this time, the old Whitman Mission site was bypassed for routes further to the south, which, following Indian trails brought the emigrants to the site of an old Indian camp at what is now Echo. Most of the wagon trains camped on the east side of the Umatilla River, directly across from the pre-historic campsite. After crossing the riverbed, they moved slowly toward The Dalles. As the pioneers left The Dalles, they either went west on the Colombia River route, or they struggled southwest over the Cascade Mountains, on the rough toll road operated by Samuel Barlow as a shortcut to Oregon City.

The route taken by the immigrants can be followed by a series of rutted hillsides, now unconnected, between Pendleton and Arlington.¹⁴ In most places where ruts remain, they do not exist as parallel ditches cut by the wagon wheels, but rather as a deep, wagon-wide single rut, formed by the mounding of dust "levees" on either side of the road. At the Ramos Ranch Site, southeast of Echo, the Oregon Trail sits at the base of a hill in the form of a wide single rut, but further up the hill, the traces of the old road become two, then five separate ditches. As the emigrants descended the steep incline, they passed side-by-side and funneled to the single road below. Still remaining at the bottom of the hill is the rock cairn, which may have directed the immigrants north over another small ridge, away from treacherous sandy wetlands along the Umatilla River. From this location, less than a day's travel north brought the immigrants to the crossing of the Umatilla River near Echo.

¹⁴Roughly 80 miles distance over what is today mostly agricultural land.



Artifacts in situ at Uvilla/Fort Henrietta site excavation

No ruts remain there in the farmland today, but the route at the crossing is marked by Koontz's 1852 grave.

The seasonal meanders of the Umatilla River must have caused the wagon trains to shift their crossing a small amount from year to year, and diaries tell us that during some years, the riverbed was dry by early fall when the emigrants arrived. However, the crossing point was required to be some distance to the north of the Ramos Ranch Site: a steep basalt ridge west of the river prevented passage for miles to the south. Taking the shortest path to a river crossing while avoiding the ridge brought the pioneers to the flat

area where the town of Echo was founded three decades later. (After leaving the river, a day's travel through eight miles of deep sand to the west of Echo Meadow's wetlands brought the immigrants to Butter Creek.)

The first Indian Agency for the Cayuse, Umatilla, and Walla Walla tribes was built on the west side of the Umatilla River, across from Echo's future town site, in July of 1851. Earlier in the year, Commissioner Anson Dart, the Superintendent of Indian Affairs, had decided to locate an agency east of the Cascades and on the emigrant road. On June 20, the Cayuse granted permission for the building of the agency on their land. In return they expected to receive a sawmill. However, Dart felt he would have more control over the tribe if he withheld the construction of the mill, and used it as leverage to guarantee safe passage for immigrants through Cayuse territory.

Dart, traveling east from The Dalles, passed the old Sandy Hollow (now Sand Hollow) battlefield near Butter Creek and arrived at the place he described as the lower crossing of the Umatilla River. He wrote that he selected this site for the agency house because it was the best location in the upper country. A map prepared by Major Granville O. Haller, a U.S. Army officer stationed at The Dalles, shows the agency at the west bank of the Umatilla River, north of the Oregon Trail, the river dividing the territory of the Umatilla tribe to the west and the Cayuse to the east. Their numbers decreased by disease, dislocation, intermarriage, and a disastrous war with the militia in 1848, the Cayuse families in the area comprised less than 150 total members by the early 1850's.

Numerous diary accounts describe the Umatilla Indian Agency building as it was viewed by the Oregon Trail immigrants during its brief existence. The first known

description of the agency was written by John Lawrence, from August 5, 1851:

Started early and drove to the crossing of the Umatilla River, here we met Cal Ely and his brother from the Sound. They came to meet their families on their way from Missouri... Here we met an old galoot by the name of Jackson who was living with a squaw. He had been to The Dalles and had bought a dress pattern for his wife and wanted the girls to make it for her. So sisters Mary and Sarah sat down in the tent and made the dress. Our company that we had traveled with most of the time for three months left us here. We met a man from Oregon, who had a contract to put up a building for an Indian Agency, he wanted to hire a few men to help him raise the building as he had hewed out the frame from green cottonwood, and they had twisted and curled up so, it was quite a job to put the frame together, but finally Harve Green and Mr. Williams and I agreed to stop 2 or 3 days and help raise the building. Father said we would meet at the Deschutes River... We went to work on the house, it was two stories high, we put the bents together in the foundation. The boss had some goods to trade to the Indians, he hired 5 to help raise, we got the first bent up and braced. The Indians went back, sat down and when ready to raise the second bent refused to help-too tired. The boss had to make a new treaty, give each a new shirt, tobacco, coffee, sugar and some of everything he had in the store, so on with each bent a new treaty. As it was framed in

4 bents we got it up by sundown and was ready to resume our journey, with orders from Dr. Dart... for 3 days work at \$3 per day.

A September, 1851 letter from the first Uilla Indian Agent, Elias Wampole, states his need for more nails to finish the structure (which had already cost \$3635.69 to construct), a request evidently fulfilled by a supply of blacksmith-made nails. By September 25, Agent Wampole had painted the building, which in the diary of immigrant John Zeiber is described as being "painted white as snow". Zeiber also noted that Wampole was selling flour, sugar, and coffee, and that a mail contractor, who carried mail between The Dalles and Salt Lake City, also had a trading tent nearby, and was offering flour at \$15 for four pounds. Also noted was an Indian selling salmon for \$2 a piece. The agency was designated a U.S. Post Office on September 26, and the postmaster, A.F. Royer, apparently conducted business from his tent. He had been licensed since July to trade with Indians at the agency.

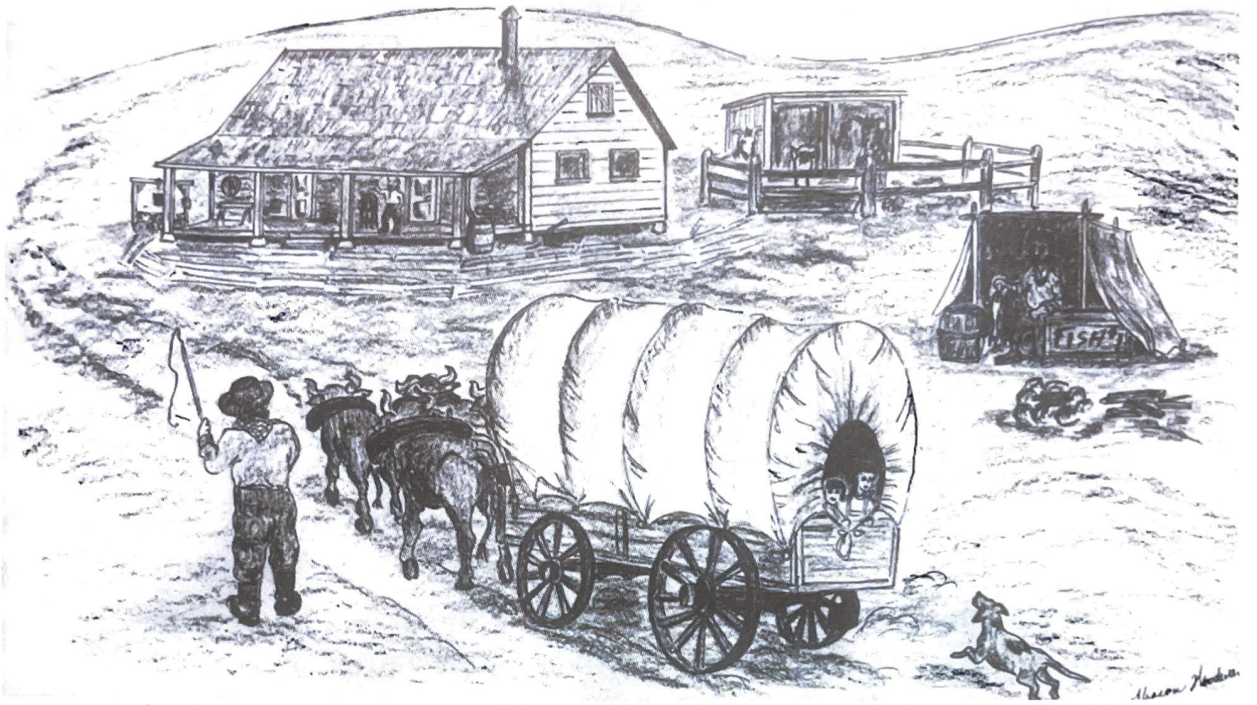
Wampole wrote that on December 18 the Nez Perce chief Otter Skin and other Indians ate with him in the agency during what he called their "Christmas visit". The dinner must have been somewhat cramped; the agent complained in a letter 12 days later that "having one room finished it has to be kitchen, parlor, office." Postmaster Royer probably left the agency prior to Christmas 1851, having sold his trading stock, including horses, to Wampole between September 25 and October 11 (The post office was officially discontinued in January 1852). A letter from L.W. Jackson dated October 11, 1851, complained to Indian Commissioner Dart that "Wampole is engaged in trade with the Indians, he has bought and sold several horses and has

a large quantity of Indian goods bought of A.F. Royer, which he is daily selling to Indians.” Jackson was pointing out the impropriety of the Indian agent profiteering from his official position.

Wampole wrote that he prepared meals of chicken and “good beef.” Fall salmon and Indian-grown potatoes were also likely available, brought by the Indians who practiced trading along the Oregon Trail. Wampole may have given his “Christmas visit” guests presents of tobacco; in his letter of December 30 he requested additional tobacco for gifts. By the mid-19th century, tobacco leaves intended to be smoked in pipes were often rolled and twisted into ropelike shapes or packed in bales or boxes. The agent gave other gifts as well: in early 1852 he presented a Britannia mug to the Cayuse chief Tautau and supplied muslin cloth for burial wrappings. Britannia metal was a pewter-like alloy of tin, copper, and antimony, which was often silver-plated.

Wampole and Royer seem to have understood early that the new Indian agency could function more successfully as a commercial rather than as a political venture. The agent encouraged Native Americans to camp near the store and develop their tastes as consumers of manufactured goods, which the agent could obtain in The Dalles or the Willamette Valley. The real economic potential of the site lay, however, in the thousands of westward-bound Oregon Trail immigrants who arrived there during the summer and fall, and it was primarily for this market that the store was stocked. Other traders were at the agency as well. Parthenia Blank wrote on October 13, 1852:

Traveled down 3 miles to the Indian agency, the first frame house we have seen since we left the Missouri River, and they have actually got a



Artist's concept of Utilia Indian Agency and Oregon Trail emigrants based on information from excavations. Drawing by Sharon Woodward

stoned-up well. The agent was gone to The Dalles, but we left 2 of our wagons there and sold 3 cattle to some traders, and put all the teams to Stephen's wagon and proceeded. Our loads are light, but our cattle are getting powerful weak, and we think best to favor them as much as possible. An Indian here had some flour for sale at 50 cents per pound. A white man has some corn, brought from Fort Walla Walla, which he sells at the rate of 6-pint cupfuls for \$1, and it sells fast.

The agency is often mentioned in Oregon Trail diaries and these entries show interesting contradictions in

the building's description. The 1852 E.W. Conyers diary notes the structure as being "one story high," while the 1853 Samuel Handsaker diary characterizes it as "a story and a half." The elastic perception of the building is still evident when actual dimensions are stated in the overland diaries. Conyers, on September 4, reported it to be "18 or 20 ft. sq." Four days later, John T. Kerns estimated it to be "40 x 20 feet." The following year, it is described on the same day as being "30 ft. long, 12 or 16 ft. wide" according to Maria Parsons Belshaw, and "30 ft. in length by 20 ft. in breadth," in the opinion of Basil N. Longworth. Samuel Handsaker described it as being "30 by 40 feet." Although the agency was constructed by U.S. government funds, archival research has found no surviving plans or drawings of the building, leaving us to rely on the diary sources and what evidence the site itself may reveal.

The lack of dependable water in the Umatilla River during the late summer and fall was alleviated by the excavation of a stone-lined well at the agency, which was noted by several diarists who undoubtedly found the cool clear water a welcome convenience. A description of the well is found in the published diary of Amelia Stewart Knight. Amelia, her husband, and seven children left Burn County, Iowa, in 1853, and their oxen-pulled wagon reached the Umatilla Agency on August 24. She wrote: "It is quite warm. Came 5 miles this morning and have just stopped at the Indian Agency to fill our cans at the well. Evening. After filling our cans with water we came on and stopped at noon to let the cattle pick dry grass as it is too warm to travel in the middle of the day." A year earlier Origen Thomson wrote:

Eight miles down the bottom the road is a considerable stream above, sinks above this point

and is perfectly dry at the crossing; I do not know how far down it rises again. Here is the residence of the Indian Agent; it is a frame, one and a half stories high, a porch on the west side, a good well, and an old-fashioned windlass graces the porch. No grass within less than a mile here.

Very few documents have survived pertaining to the Uvilla Agency, but the partial 1853 immigration registration has survived in an *Oregonian* newspaper article that was published on October 29, 1853. It remains as a very significant document in providing historians with a realistic view of the actual social groups traveling the Oregon Trail. The roster was taken by Thomas K. Williams, an assistant to R.R. Thompson, the 1853 Indian agent at Uvilla (Thompson does not seem to have been on as good terms as Agent Wampole had been with the nearby tribes-he reported on July 20, 1854 that the only way to deal satisfactorily with the Indians was to take title to their land and force them on to reservations).

According to the list, 1,269 wagons stopped at the agency between July 20 and September 30. On the 45 days that registrants were recorded, 5,169 men, women, and children were counted. Livestock included 9,077 oxen, 6,518 cows, and 2,009 horses. Mules, which later became the favored draught stock, numbered only 327, but herds of sheep were listed at about 1,500 animals. It was these great herds of livestock that must have created clouds of dust visible above the arid landscape for miles.

Thompson's list also includes the head of family, followed by dependents. Some on the list appear only descriptively: "one Negro" was written on August 20 and



The Umatilla River looking south from the "Lower" Oregon Trail Crossing. The River probably looked the same in 1850.

again on August 23. Whether these individuals were men or women, free or slave, is unknown, but Oregon had passed African American exclusion laws in 1844. Even so, a friend of Oregon pioneer Ezra Meeker was George Washington Bush, a free Black man from Missouri who traveled west on the Oregon Trail, and who financed at least two other families for what were among the first Oregon Trail wagon trains in 1844.

On September 27, the Thompson list includes 6 packers, and on the last day included in the registration, September 30, the somewhat cryptic "28 men" is the only entry. On September 5, a group of 58 men, 14 wives, 18 sons, and 36 daughters is listed only with the notation "passed while sick", leaving the reader to determine whether Mr. Thompson or the travelers were ill. The list also includes a significant number of "unknowns" comprising 280 men, women, and children on September 2, and another group of 130 on September 5.

Another revealing aspect of the list is that men listed alone account for about 30% of the immigrants in 1853. Few single women traveled the trail alone, but on July 25,

the names "Mary Elder", "Miss Brown", and "Miss Taylor" appear, as do the minimal families "Mrs. E. Easton" and "Mrs. Penny", each with a single daughter. On September 22, near the end of the immigration season, among the 104 names are two single women, and five women alone with their children, including a Mrs. Havard with her nine children. Male single parents are also listed, and on July 25, included a J. Manuel with his three sons and three daughters, and a Mr. Anderson with one son and one daughter. It is interesting that although the stereotypes of the Oregon Trail immigrants have customarily depicted struggling nuclear families, actual groups were more varied. Families listed with both parents and at least one child constructed only 17 of the 95 named registrants on July 25. There were also, on that date, eight childless couples, 54 single men, and 2 sets of what were probably brothers. All-male groups are also listed; on August 13, all of the 12 registrants were males, including one man with his son, and two sets of brothers. On September 21, a man named C. Davis, with his seven sons, arrived with what probably were his two brothers, W. and T. Davis. On other days were some large families, including a Dr. R.C. Hill, with his wife and ten children, and the R. Price family, with eleven offspring. On September 13, of the sixteen families who registered, there were no single men alone, but one single man with children, two single women with children, two childless couples, and eleven nuclear families with children.

The Umatilla Agency did not last long after the 1853 register was made: two years later, during the first months of the Yakima War, the building was destroyed by fire. When westward migration again resumed toward Oregon in the 1860's, other routes were favored over the old crossing at the Umatilla.